



Golden chance: World Cup disappointment stings, but India can bounce back by defending its Asian Games title and securing LA 2028 qualification. HOCKEYINDIA

The favourites have something to prove

India's hockey teams arrive at the Asian Games with **contrasting ambitions**, as the men seek redemption and the women chase a rare gold.

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Despite the Indian teams' mixed performances at the recently concluded World Cups, with the men finishing eighth and the women placing a commendable fifth, the men's side will enter the Asian Games as the overwhelming favourite for the gold.

Craig Fulton's India has been the undisputed king of the continent for the last four years. Since 2023, the men have won every continental competition they have contested, including two Asian Champions

Trophy titles, the Asia Cup and the Asian Games, without losing a single game.

However, a second successive gold medal, a feat no team has achieved since 2006, will be anything but straightforward. India's challenge will begin at Kakamigahara in the second half of September, with the team still reeling from its disastrous World Cup campaign. The Asian Games will now serve as a make-or-break competition for Fulton and several senior players in this side.

Defenders Amit Rohidas, Jarmanpreet Singh, Sumit, Jugraj Singh, Yashdeep Siwach, Sanjay Rana

and Harmanpreet Singh all had forgettable outings as India shipped 19 goals, the tournament's fifth-worst defensive record. Even Pakistan scored three, aided by sloppy handling of possession.

Almost every department, from goalkeeping to the forward line, had a tournament to forget, with Harmanpreet's dragflicks from Penalty Corners the notable exception. Despite a crooked back, his world-class finishing from short corners repeatedly dragged India into contests when it struggled to find goals from open play.

Harmanpreet's heroics will need to be backed up in field play by his